



Having attended numerous Indian Premier League (IPL) matches as a fan at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, the Diary was now set for its maiden El Clasico — this time, as a journalist.

Arriving four hours before the toss, the Diary found itself immersed in a vibrant sea of yellow, soaking in the pre-game atmosphere of Chennai Super Kings' season opener against Mumbai Indians.

Since its experimental beginnings in 2008, the IPL has witnessed explosive growth in both popularity and revenue. However, its commercial impact stretches far beyond the tournament itself.

"Outside of selling jerseys and flags here, I do odd jobs, but I never have a steady income. The IPL and other international matches here are not just entertainment; they're a crucial source of income for people like me," explained Rakesh, one of the many hawkers surrounding the stadium.

Despite knowing that most in the

crowd would be supporting the home side, Rakesh cleverly caters to away fans as well, selling first-copy jerseys, caps, and flags.

Like many other vendors, he embodies the adage "make hay while the sun shines," making the most of the three-month IPL season to secure his livelihood.

Nigamanth P

Maiden century

Ticket sales in India are always a tricky affair. India struggled when Coldplay came along, with the popular public sentiment being one of collective disappointment. The IPL is no different. When your team has a penchant for big scores, the desperation to secure entry means ticket demand skyrockets. The black market promptly responds.

On the eve of SRH's campaign opener against Rajasthan Royals, the local police nabbed a few people trying to make a quick buck by selling tickets at inflated rates. While the men in uniform were quick to dismiss it as

Big bucks, big hits: Ishan Kishan, bought by Sunrisers Hyderabad for Rs.11.25 crore at the IPL 2025 mega auction, repaid the faith with a barnstorming century in his team's campaign opener. **K. V. S. GIRI**

a regular occurrence, the novelty for the TV cameras present — rushing to secure footage of the arrest to loop into the evening primetime news — wasn't lost on anyone.

The action was just as frenetic on the field. Rain predictions came true, except precipitation made way for pyrotechnics.

The stadium DJ, who had to rely on local tunes to pump up the crowd, soon got help from Travis Head and Ishan Kishan's fireworks with the bat. Kishan, a new SRH recruit, reciprocated the love from the fans, after the disappointments of 2024, with a maiden IPL ton and flying kisses to the stands. Can't do better than that for first impressions, right?

Anirudh Velamuri